could work for deterrence, ensure Washington and Moscow knew where the other stood, and reassure the Indian public. In an internal memo, Jha also laid out why he thought such a legal commitment was unnecessary: "guarantee or no guarantee," if there was a "Chinese attack on India in the near future, both the USA and the USSR would undoubtedly take the strongest possible action." He argued that this was also a reason India did not have to go nuclear. Furthermore, if India produced nuclear weapons, it would "greatly reduce the restraint on China using nuclear weapons against us and also weaken the political compulsions on the USA and the USSR to come to our help in such an eventuality." In any case, India could not catch up with China.

Simultaneously, Jha acknowledged that it would be "living dangerously" to assume that Moscow and Washington would come to India's assistance against China. India needed to "recognise that conditions may change." Even if there was a guarantee, it would hardly be "fool-proof, because if the political factors are unfavourable, some excuse can always be found to delay action, to act half-heartedly and ineffectively, or not to act at all."[229] Doubts about reliability of external benefactors meant that even a guarantee "could be no substitute for its own defence. The implementation of such a guarantee, when the time arose, would necessarily depend on prevailing political circumstances."[230]

For the Indian foreign minister, this questionable reliability meant that India needed to keep its nuclear option open. As Chagla said in parliament, "We do not know what the alignments of power might be after four or five years."[231] For L. K. Jha, this was also a reason not to sign the NPT, even if Moscow linked any guarantee to Indian participation.[232]

The mood in India subsequently soured on both the NPT and the assurance. Critics stated that the government had not thought through what a guarantee would entail, including, potentially, military bases. Others questioned the reliability, criticizing the government for seeking "a nuclear umbrella without a handle."[233] The potential credibility and desirability of any guarantee were debated at a meeting of the Congress Party.[234] By the time the Indian deputy prime minister visited the US in September 1967, India's lack of interest in a guarantee was publicly evident.[235] In Washington, Desai "discounted [the] efficacy of security assurances." He also repeated Indian objections to the NPT.[236]